



Hero MotoCorp has launched Hero HF Deluxe Flex Fuel and Hero Splendor Plus Flex Fuel

carbon neutral. If this is not done, it will be very difficult for OEMs to introduce FFVs,” says Gulati. OEMs and the government are talking on all these enablers, he adds.

FFVs are unlikely to generate significant volumes in the near term due to limited availability of models and need for a nationwide network of dispensing pumps, Maruti Suzuki’s Bharti told analysts during the company’s Q4 FY26 earnings call.

“We need more models. We need energy-based parity between ethanol and petrol prices. It is a futuristic plan. The volumes will be minimal at this stage. They will grow, say, five years to 10 years from now,” he says.

For consumers, E100 vehicles

could cost 3–8% more due to ethanol-resistant components, while higher fuel consumption may offset savings from cheaper ethanol, says Ravi G Bhatia, President & Director of JATO Dynamics India. “A premature push towards E100 could strain automakers’ capital allocation and potentially slow EV adoption by diverting investments and policy focus,” says Bhatia.

Hero’s Chitale is hopeful that the government will encourage oil companies to make the fuel available after the West Asia crisis. “Those dialogues have been going on between the industry and the government,” says Chitale.

“We are all for increasing the biofuel content in the energy mix. That is a sure shot way to make

ourselves *atmanirbhar*. We are all for it, whether it comes through E25 or it through a rapid shift to E85 and E100. SIAM has given a representation to the government saying it is in favour of flex fuel. Let’s work out a roadmap and policy on how the fuel would be made available,” says Chitale.

The debate around India’s clean mobility transition, say industry leaders, cannot be reduced to a single technology. By 2030, India’s car market is expected to swell to nearly six million vehicles annually. Even in the most optimistic scenario, EV penetration may reach only about 20%. That still leaves nearly 4.8 million ICE cars.

As millions of new ICE vehicles continue to enter Indian roads through the decade, the country’s dependence on imported fossil fuels could deepen instead of coming down. The International Energy Agency has already flagged India as a major driver of future fossil fuel demand growth, projecting that more than one-third of global oil demand growth could come from the country.

“This scenario is going to be disastrous not only for the environment but also the economy. The CAD is going to go through the roof,” reckons Toyota’s Gulati. “If you go electric, you are increasing the import bill for EV parts. That is going to reduce when indigenisation happens. But that too is going to take some time,” he adds.

There is no doubt that FFVs will increase the offtake of ethanol, leading to better incomes for farmers. But only time will tell if it works in India. While we can sit in our drawing rooms and wish for energy transition, it is ultimately the consumer who has to make it happen. **BT**

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